Alton Michaux

Backend Lead Developer
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SUMMARY

Backend lead developer with 5 years at Code The Dream Labs, working in Ruby on Rails and Django with React on the front end. Owns releases, production infrastructure and senior code review alongside feature work, mentors apprentices, and builds AI tooling into how the team works.

SKILLS

Languages and frameworks: Ruby, Rails, Python, Django, Django REST Framework, JavaScript, TypeScript, React, Next.js
Data and infrastructure: PostgreSQL, Elasticsearch, Docker, Heroku, DigitalOcean, AWS (S3, CloudFront), Linux, cron
Practices and tools: CI/CD, GitHub Actions, release management, code review, RSpec, Capybara, pytest, Swagger, Scrum, Claude Code

EXPERIENCE

Code The Dream Labs, Durham, NC 10/2021 to Present
Backend Lead Developer 10/2022 to Present

Vamos*: field operations platform for social impact organizations (Rails, React, Postgres, Elasticsearch)*

- Own the release cycle end to end: 40+ releases since 2024, from release branch to production, including a major redesign, hotfixes and rollbacks
- Senior code reviewer on a codebase with 100+ contributors over its lifetime
- Run the team's scrum, backlog refinement and sprint planning
- Keep production healthy on Heroku: stack upgrades, slug size limits, Elasticsearch recovery and email deliverability
- Triage dependency updates by checking whether each advisory is reachable from app code, then plan merges in batches that don't conflict
- Build features across the full stack, with RSpec and Capybara tests and Swagger API docs

H2Data*: civic data search platform with a public API, since 2024 (Django, DRF, Postgres, DigitalOcean)*

- Lead developer on the rewrite, from data ingestion through the public API
- Leading the production move to DigitalOcean: private networking, managed Postgres with connection pooling, scheduled ingestion and DNS cutover
- Built CI that tags every image by commit, so any deploy can roll back in one step
- Prepare the Django app for production: configuration, TLS, throttling and health checks
- Track down schema and data quality bugs in the upstream data feeds

Team lead and mentoring*: alongside both projects*

- Hold regular 1:1s and write quarterly evidence-based evaluations for apprentices on the team
- Interview and assess apprenticeship candidates, and sit on staff hiring panels
- Taught a practicum course in 2026 and run group mock interviews
- Built Claude Code tooling for code review, dependency triage and standups, tuned to each codebase, with a person signing off on everything posted

Backend Apprentice 10/2021 to 10/2022

- Wrote and refactored server-side Rails code on Vamos, including urgent client-reported issues
- Wrote test specs with RSpec and Capybara, API docs with Swagger, and developer documentation for major features

Outbound Door Closer, Target Corporation, Newton, NC 04/2021 to 05/2022

- Managed outbound freight sorting and truck closing, and was offered a trainer position within 90 days

PROJECTS

Work Smarter: task and resume management app, built solo (Django, DRF, Next.js, TypeScript, Postgres, Docker). Includes a public API with token auth, Google Calendar sync, AI resume analysis and generation, and CI.

EDUCATION

Practicum, Web Development, Code The Dream, Durham, NC 09/2021
Certification (255 hours), Ruby on Rails, SQL and relational databases, Code The Dream 06/2021
Certification (250 hours), HTML, CSS and JavaScript, Code The Dream 01/2020